

COLLECTION · BUYERS

Property Visit & Inspection Checklist

The buyer's checklist for seeing past the decor

READ BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Important notice

This guide is provided for informational and educational purposes only. It offers general information about real estate in Quebec and does not constitute personalized real estate, legal, tax or financial advice. As every real estate situation is different, it is recommended that you consult the appropriate professionals before making any decision regarding a real estate transaction.

© 2026 Émilie Cauvier — La Bibliothèque. All rights reserved. Any reproduction, distribution, sharing or resale, in whole or in part, by any means whatsoever, is strictly prohibited without prior written authorization. This guide is intended for the personal use of the purchaser.

Property Visit & Inspection Checklist

The buyer's checklist for seeing past the decor

A beautiful kitchen and careful home staging can make you forget the essentials: the structure, water, electricity, the roof. This guide gives you an inspector's eye for your visits, room by room and system by system.

It doesn't replace the professional inspection — which is essential — but it helps you spot the signals from the very first visit, ask the right questions and decide which properties are worth an offer.

After each chapter, a lined “My notes” page serves as your visit logbook: write down what you see, property by property.

A successful visit is a methodical one: you look in the right order, note the right clues, and tell what's easily fixed from what's expensive. This guide gives you a room-by-room grid, from the exterior to the systems.

Goal: spot the real issues behind the staging, and turn your observations into precise questions for the inspection.

CHAPTER

Before going in: the exterior and the lot

Reading the property from the sidewalk and the lot.

- Lot: does the slope carry water away from the foundation, or toward it?
- Visible foundation: significant cracks, crumbling, moisture marks?
- Roof: apparent age, curled or missing shingles, moss, sagging?
- Gutters and drainage: present, clear, directed away from the house?
- Exterior cladding, windows and doors: condition, caulking, signs of rot?
- Trees too close, parking, immediate neighbourhood and noise.

The exterior tells the story of general upkeep: a neglected envelope often heralds surprises inside.

Even before ringing the bell, take thirty seconds on the sidewalk: the siting, the slope of the lot and the general condition already say a lot. A property well maintained outside often is inside too; the opposite is a signal not to ignore.

EMILIE'S TIP

Walk all the way around the house before going in. The façade is put on show; it's often the back and the sides that tell the truth about upkeep.

CHAPTER

The basement: where everything shows

Detecting water, cracks and the state of the systems.

- Damp or musty smells, water stains on the walls and floor.
- Cracks in the slab or foundation walls (fine vs significant).
- Signs of infiltration, water-level marks, is there a sump pump?
- Insulation, vermiculite (possible asbestos) in old attics/walls.
- Furnace, water heater, electrical service: visible age and condition.

In Quebec, a dry, healthy basement is a major asset; water is the building's number-one enemy and the source of the most costly repairs.

The basement is the most honest place in a house: it's where water, cracks and patch-job repairs show. Be wary of a basement freshly repainted right before the sale — it can hide signs of infiltration. A dehumidifier running constantly is also a clue.

EMILIE'S TIP

Open your nostrils as much as your eyes in the basement. A damp smell someone is trying to mask (strong air freshener, a running dehumidifier) always deserves a direct question.

CHAPTER

The systems: electrical, plumbing, heating

Checking the functional heart of the house.

Electrical

- Panel: capacity (100 A minimum often desirable), a brand with known risks, wires properly labelled?
- Presence of old problematic wiring; outlets with grounding.

Plumbing and heating

- Water pressure and flow, marks under the sinks, age of the water heater.
- Type of heating (electric baseboards, furnace, heat pump) and costs.
- Buried or above-ground oil tank: a point of vigilance and insurability.

For the systems, note the age of the big components (roof, heating, water heater, windows): those are the ones that are expensive to replace. A dated electrical panel, old plumbing or a heating system near end of life should factor into your post-purchase budget.

EMILIE'S TIP

Ask for the last 12 months of Hydro-Québec bills. They reveal the true heating cost — often more telling than a listing description.

CHAPTER

The interior, room by room

Spotting the clues behind the décor.

- Floors: level, squeaks, stains, floors that “lean”.
- Windows: condensation between the panes (seal failure), easy to open.
- Ceilings and corners: yellow rings (past leaks), cracks.
- Kitchen and bathrooms: ventilation, caulking, signs of water damage.
- Doors that close poorly or stair-step cracks: signs of structural movement.

A recent renovation is pleasant, but always ask: was it done with permits and by professionals? A cosmetic renovation can hide a problem rather than fix it.

Inside, look beyond the décor: level floors, doors that close well, no rings on the ceiling, windows with no condensation between the panes. Décor is easily changed; the structure and envelope are not. Don't fall in love with a kitchen to the point of forgetting a foundation that's moving.

EMILIE'S TIP

Be wary of a single freshly repainted wall, especially in the basement or under a window: sometimes it's a touch-up... sometimes it's covering a recent water stain.

CHAPTER

From the visit to the professional inspection

Turning your observations into a decision and an offer condition.

Your visit is there to filter and target. As soon as a property seriously interests you, make a promise to purchase conditional on an inspection by a recognized professional, and go along on site.

Hand them your notes: the points you spotted will guide their attention. Their report will confirm the scale of the problems and give you leverage to renegotiate, demand fixes, or withdraw if necessary.

Your visit doesn't replace the inspection: it's there to filter and target. As soon as a property seriously interests you, make a promise to purchase conditional on an inspection by a recognized professional, and go along to ask your questions and understand the report.

EMILIE'S TIP

Keep this visit logbook for each property. Compared with a cool head, it keeps you from confusing the crush of the moment with the best decision.

IN PRACTICE

Action plan

Your next steps, concretely.

This week

1. Print this checklist and use it at every visit.
2. Ask for the energy bills and the renovation history.

Within 30 days

1. Retain a recognized inspector and plan for the inspection condition.
2. Compare my visit logbooks with a cool head before making an offer.

Next

1. Have the chosen property inspected, going along with the inspector.

My visit kit

1. Bring a flashlight, a level (or a marble) and something to take notes and photos.
2. Note the age of the major components and ask for invoices for recent work.

REFERENCES

Resources & glossary

- Pre-purchase inspection: a professional examination, to be made a condition of the offer.
 - Seal failure: a window fogged between the panes, to be replaced.
 - Sump pump: drains water from the basement, a sign of a damp area.
 - Oil tank: buried or above-ground, an insurability point.
 - Stair-step crack: a possible clue of foundation movement.
-
- Building envelope: roof, walls, windows and insulation — the barrier against water and cold.
 - Seal failure: condensation between the panes of a thermal window.
 - French drain: perimeter drain that carries water away around the foundation.
 - Inspection condition: a clause making the purchase dependent on a satisfactory report.
 - Apparent defect: a defect visible on a normal examination, not covered by the legal warranty.

GOING FURTHER

Quiz — test your knowledge

1. The first reflex outside is to check:

- A) The colour of the door
- B) That the lot carries water away from the foundation
- C) The name of the street
- D) The curtains

2. In the basement, the number-one enemy is:

- A) Paint
- B) Water and moisture
- C) Light
- D) Carpet

3. Vermiculite in an old building may contain:

- A) Gold
- B) Asbestos
- C) Drinking water
- D) Nothing

4. A window fogged between the panes indicates:

- A) A good seal
- B) A seal failure
- C) Rain
- D) Good insulation

5. To know the true heating cost, ask for:

- A) The neighbour's opinion
- B) The last 12 months of Hydro-Québec bills
- C) The listing sheet
- D) The weather

6. “Stair-step” cracks and sticking doors can signal:

- A) Nice décor
- B) Structural movement
- C) Good ventilation
- D) Nothing

7. A recent renovation should always prompt the question:

- A) What colour?
- B) Was it done with permits and by pros?
- C) How many photos?
- D) When is dinner?

8. This checklist:

- A) Replaces the professional inspection
- B) Complements the visit but doesn't replace the inspection
- C) Is useless
- D) Is for the notary

Answer key

- 1. **B** — Drainage protects the foundation (ch. 1).
- 2. **B** — Water causes the most costly repairs (ch. 2).
- 3. **B** — It's a health point of vigilance (ch. 2).
- 4. **B** — The thermal seal is broken (ch. 4).
- 5. **B** — The bills give the real cost (ch. 3).
- 6. **B** — Possible clues of foundation movement (ch. 4).
- 7. **B** — Cosmetics can hide a problem (ch. 4).
- 8. **B** — The professional inspection remains essential (ch. 5).

Signé PAR Em

*Thank you for reading. May this guide help you
decide with confidence, with all the information
in hand.*

© 2026 Émilie Cauvier — La Bibliothèque. All rights reserved. Any reproduction, distribution, sharing or resale, in whole or in part, by any means whatsoever, is strictly prohibited without prior written authorization.
This guide is intended for the personal use of the purchaser.